

Before We Move In

Everything to settle before the keys change hands — what to decide on your own first, and what belongs on the table when the two of you sit down.

UNIT	RENT	YOUR HALF	DEPOSIT	MOVING
2 bed / 2 bath	R8,800	R4,400	R8,800	Month end

Rent covers sanitation, refuse and security. Electricity and internet are on top.

Agenda

Eight items, in the order worth working through them. Money first — it is concrete, and it warms the room up for the harder ones. Tick each off as it is genuinely settled, not merely mentioned.

01	Money and the lease Signatures, liability, the split, and how money actually moves each month	☐
02	Rooms, parking and furniture Who sleeps where, who owns what, what happens to jointly bought things	☐
03	Running the home Cleaning, food, laundry, quiet hours, electricity habits	☐
04	People in the home Guests, the ministry boundary, and how it gets held	☐
05	The view from outside What the church and your families are told, by whom, and when	☐
06	Two roles, one kitchen Keeping pastor and flatmate separate under one roof	☐

07	If something changes	☐
Conflict route, notice periods, exit terms, and the relationship itself		
08	Move-in week	☐
Inspection, photographs, keys, meters, body corporate rules		

Each item has space for notes underneath it. Anything left unresolved goes to the actions block on the last page.



Decide your position before you walk in

You cannot negotiate a position you have not decided. Work through this alone first — not to build a case, but so that when a question comes up you answer from what you actually want rather than from what is easiest to agree to in the moment.

What you can and cannot absorb

From month four your share settles at about **R5,430 a month** including transport, against R12,000 available. That is comfortable. The thin part is the first month, and the thing that keeps it safe is the deposit being split over three instalments.

YOUR SHARE, ONCE YOU ARE BOTH IN

LINE	PER MONTH
Rent, half	R4,400
Electricity, half	R310
Water	R0
Internet, half	R400
Transport	R320
Total	R5,430

- ☐ Write down your true monthly ceiling for everything housing-related.
Not the number you hope for — the number above which you would have to borrow.
- ☐ Decide your limit for unplanned joint spending.
A cleaner, a couch, a coffee machine. Below what figure would you agree without needing to think?
- ☐ Confirm the date your deposit refund lands, and whether it arrives before the first rent payment.
It is the only cash in your plan. If it is late, the first month does not work.

PREPARE FOR THIS ONE

If your pastor earns considerably more than you, they may propose things in good faith that you cannot afford — furniture, a weekly cleaner, splitting something large. **Decide now that you will say "that is above what I budgeted" plainly, and without explaining your finances.** It is a complete sentence. Rehearse it, because the moment it is needed is the moment it will be hardest to say.

MY NUMBERS ceiling, joint-spend limit, refund date

The flat itself

- ☐ Which bedroom do you want, and why?

Light, noise, size, proximity to the front door. Know your first choice and your fallback.

- ☐ What would you trade to get it?

A slightly larger share of rent, the smaller cupboard, the second parking bay.

- ☐ List what you are bringing, and what you still need to buy.

- ☐ Decide what you are *not* willing to share.

Some things should simply be yours. Naming them now avoids a small resentment later.

MY PREFERENCES

How you actually live

Be honest here rather than aspirational. The version of yourself you describe in this meeting is the standard you will be held to in month five.

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- ☐ Your real cleanliness standard, not your best week.
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- ☐ What time you need the flat quiet, on weeknights and on Sundays.
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- ☐ How many evenings a week you need the place to yourself.
This is the question people skip and then quietly suffer over. Put a number on it.
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- ☐ Whether you want to share food and cooking, or keep them separate.
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- ☐ Your honest limit on people coming into the home during the week.
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MY STANDARDS

Your line

Before any of the rest, know the answer to this one. Not to threaten anyone with it — just so that you recognise the situation if it ever arrives.

What would have to happen for me to want to leave?

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- ☐ Name it, and write down what you would do if it happened.
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- ☐ Identify one person outside the church you could talk to honestly about living here.
You will need this. Item seven explains why.
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MY LINE and who I would call

The eight items in full

The detail behind each agenda line. The questions set in *italics* are the ones worth asking out loud, more or less as written. Write what you agree in the notes box under each item — not what you discussed, but what you decided.

01 Money and the lease

THE LEASE ITSELF

- ☐ Do both names go on the lease?
Push for yes. If only one of you signs, the other has no legal right to be there and the signatory carries the whole risk alone.

- ☐ Read the liability clause together.
Almost every shared lease is joint and several: if one of you does not pay, the landlord can pursue the other for the full amount. Both of you should know this before signing, not after.

- ☐ Lease length, annual escalation percentage, and notice period.

- ☐ Does the lease allow a replacement tenant if one of you leaves early?

- ☐ Get the R1,100 admin and credit check confirmed as once-off, and check whether it is per lease or per person.

THE SPLIT

- ☐ Is rent split evenly, or weighted if one bedroom is meaningfully better?

- ☐ Deposit: R4,400 each, over three instalments. Confirm the landlord has agreed to this in writing.

- ☐ Write down who paid what, and keep it.
A year from now, the deposit refund is split according to this record. Without it, it gets split according to memory.

MECHANICS

- ☐ Does each of you pay the landlord directly, or does one pay and the other transfer?

Direct is cleaner. If one pays, that person is carrying the other's credit risk every month.

☐ What date does money move, relative to both your salary dates?

☐ Who tops up prepaid electricity, and how is it reconciled?

One person buying and the other settling up is the most common friction point in a shared flat. Agree the method now.

☐ Internet, in whose name and on whose debit order?

☐ Consumables — dishwashing liquid, toilet paper, cleaning supplies. A small monthly kitty, or alternate months?

If one of us is short one month, what do we do — and how do we say it without it becoming a big thing?

01 • WHAT WE AGREED

02 Rooms, parking and furniture

☐ Bedroom allocation. Settle it now, and say whether it is revisited later or fixed.

☐ How many parking bays come with the unit, and who uses what.

☐ Storage — cupboards, the balcony, anything communal.

☐ Inventory: who owns each item in the shared spaces.

Write it down. It matters only once — on the day someone moves out — and then it matters a lot.

☐ Anything bought jointly: agree in advance who keeps it and whether the other is bought out.

☐ Contents insurance — separately, or one policy split?

03 Running the home

- ☐ Cleaning: a rota between you, or a cleaner you split?

Once a week in Johannesburg runs roughly R1,600 a month, so about R800 each. That is real money against your budget — decide it deliberately.

- ☐ Agree what "clean" means for the kitchen and the lounge, specifically.

Dishes done the same night, or by the next morning? Vague standards are how this goes wrong.

- ☐ Food: shared, separate, or shared staples with separate meals.

- ☐ Fridge and cupboard space.

- ☐ Laundry — who uses what, when.

- ☐ Quiet hours on weeknights, and how Sunday mornings run.

- ☐ Electricity habits.

Prepaid means every heater and every long shower is visible in a shared cost. Worth one sentence now rather than a passive-aggressive one later.

04 People in the home

THE LINE ALREADY DRAWN

The flat is not a ministry venue. Church members do not come here. That is settled, and it is a good line — a pastor's home otherwise tends to become semi-public without anyone deciding that it should. This part of the conversation is not about negotiating it. It is about making sure it holds without either of you having to defend it at the door.

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- ☐ Say it out loud, both of you, so it is a shared decision rather than an assumption you are carrying alone.
 - ☐ How does the church come to understand that this address is private — and who handles that?
Better it is known from the start than corrected after the first person arrives.
 - ☐ If someone turns up anyway, what happens?
Agree the response now so neither of you has to improvise while a person is standing outside.
 - ☐ Is there any exception at all, or is it an absolute?
"Never" and "only if we both agree first" are both fine answers. Ambiguity is not.
 - ☐ Pastoral calls will still happen inside the flat even when visitors do not.
Where are they taken, and what is expected of you about what you overhear? Agree the confidentiality expectation explicitly rather than leaving you to guess.
 - ☐ Late-night emergencies — what does your pastor actually do, and does any of it involve the flat or you?
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ORDINARY GUESTS

Separate question, and the most common source of friction between any two people sharing a home. Worth being specific.

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- ☐ How much notice before someone comes over?
 - ☐ Overnight guests — allowed, how often, how much warning?
 - ☐ Family staying over, and for how long.
 - ☐ Does either of you have a veto, and how is it used without offence?
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How many evenings a week can I count on this being just a home?

05 The view from outside

Other people will form a story about this living arrangement whether or not you give them one. It is much better to have agreed your own version first.

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- ☐ What does the church know, and what will it be told?
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- ☐ Who says it, and when?
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- ☐ Does anyone in church leadership need to know before you move in?
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- ☐ Your families — same questions.
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- ☐ If someone asks you directly, what do you say?
- Agree the wording. Two people improvising separately is how a simple arrangement becomes a rumour.
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06 Two roles, one kitchen

They are your pastor and they will now also be the person who did not take the bins out. Those two things live in the same flat now, and they need separating deliberately.

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- ☐ Agree out loud that household matters are decided between equals.
- Spiritual authority does not extend to the dishes. Saying so once, early, makes it much easier to invoke later.
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- ☐ Keep pastoral conversations and household admin in separate conversations.
- ☐ Agree that either of you can raise a household problem without it being read as a spiritual one.
- ☐ Be clear about what they will and will not learn about your finances — and that it stays between you.

If I am unhappy about something small, how do I tell you — and can I tell you as a flatmate rather than as a member of your church?

06 • WHAT WE AGREED

07 If something changes

The item both of you will want to skip. Do it anyway — and do it now, while everyone is glad about the flat, because it cannot be done well later.

THE CONFLICT ROUTE

When something goes wrong between flatmates, most people talk to someone they trust. **Your usual person is the other flatmate.** That route is closed here, and closing it without noticing is the specific risk of this arrangement.

- ☐ Name one neutral person, now, who both of you accept.
Ideally outside the church, or at least not under their authority. Someone you can both call if a disagreement will not resolve.

- ☐ Agree a regular check-in — fifteen minutes, monthly.
Small things raised early stay small. Left alone, they compound.

IF ONE OF YOU WANTS OUT

- ☐ How much notice do you give each other? Sixty days is a fair default.

- ☐ Who finds the replacement, and who has to approve them?
- ☐ Who covers the shortfall while the room is empty?
- ☐ How is the deposit settled — at exit, or when the lease ends?

IF THE RELATIONSHIP CHANGES

You have said there is more between you than a shared address. That is yours, and none of what follows is a judgement on it. But you asked not to be surprised, so three things are worth saying plainly.

The lease will outlive any change between you. If things end in month three, you are still contractually bound to each other for the rest of the term. Decide now, while it costs nothing, who would move out and on what notice.

A relationship between a pastor and a member of their congregation carries professional exposure in most churches — often more for them than for you. Whatever you have both decided about that, decide it together and decide it before you sign, not in the middle of a difficult conversation with someone else.

The imbalance is real even when the affection is. They hold spiritual authority over you and, once you sign, a shared financial obligation with you. That does not make the relationship wrong. It does mean you should keep your own money, your own exit, and your own outside person — not because you expect to need them, but because having them is what lets you stay in this freely.

If this changed between us, what would we do about the flat — and can we agree that now, in writing, while it is easy?

07 • WHAT WE AGREED

08 Move-in week

- ☐ Ingoing inspection with the agent — walk it together.
- ☐ Photograph everything, date-stamped, including every existing mark.
This is what your R8,800 deposit comes back on. Twenty minutes now.
- ☐ Both of you sign the inspection report and each keep a copy.
- ☐ Keys, access tags, biometrics registered for both of you.
- ☐ Prepaid electricity meter number and top-up method.
- ☐ Get the body corporate rules and read them.
Noise, guests, parking, the pool, use of the gym and activity centre. They bind you regardless of what you and the landlord agreed.
- ☐ Internet ordered, with an installation date.
- ☐ Emergency contacts exchanged — one person each, outside the flat.
- ☐ Address updated: bank, employer, medical aid, deliveries.

08 • DATES AND WHO IS DOING WHAT

Write down the six that matter

Not a contract, and not a sign of distrust. It exists because memory is unreliable and because the friendship is worth protecting from an argument about who paid for the couch. One page, both signatures, a copy each.

FLATMATE AGREEMENT

1. **Money.** Rent is split ____ / _____. Electricity, internet and consumables are split ____ / _____. Payment is made ____ by the ____ of each month.
2. **Deposit.** Each paid R4,400. On exit it is refunded in the same proportion, less any damage caused by the person responsible for it.
3. **Notice.** Either of us gives the other ____ days' notice before moving out. The person leaving finds a replacement, subject to the other's agreement.
4. **Guests.** ____ hours' notice. Overnight guests: _____. **The flat is not used for ministry and church members do not visit**, except _____.
5. **Joint spending.** Neither commits the other to anything over R____ without agreement.
6. **Disputes.** Anything we cannot settle between us goes to _____, whom we both accept. Household decisions are made as equals.

SIGNED & DATE

SIGNED & DATE

Left open, and who is doing it

Anything the meeting could not settle. Put a name and a date against each one, or it will not happen.

ACTIONS what · who · by when

Most of this will never be needed. You will settle into a rhythm, and the page will sit in a drawer. That is the point of it — the arrangements that last are the ones where nobody has to guess what was agreed, and where both people kept the freedom to change their mind.